

The Indian Premier League A Cricketing Revolution

How a T20 franchise league reshaped world cricket, built billion-dollar brands, and changed the way the game is played, watched, and monetised

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A League Like No Other

Every April, something strange happens across India. Offices empty out early, WhatsApp groups fill with predictions, and entire cities pause for three hours a night. This is not a national holiday or an election. It is the Indian Premier League — and for two months every year, it becomes the most-watched show on the subcontinent.

When the Indian Premier League was announced in 2007, cricket purists were skeptical. Twenty overs a side, cheerleaders, city franchises, player auctions — it looked less like Test cricket's dignified cousin and more like a carnival built to sell soft drinks. Nearly two decades later, that carnival has become the financial engine of world cricket, the single most valuable cricket property on the planet, and arguably the most successful sports league launched anywhere this century.

The IPL's genius was never really about the cricket, though the cricket has been extraordinary. It was about recognising, earlier and more completely than any cricket board before it, that the sport could be repackaged as three hours of prime-time entertainment: unpredictable, star-studded, and endlessly marketable. In doing so, the league didn't just change how Twenty20 cricket is played. It changed who plays it, who owns it, who watches it, and how much money moves through the sport every single year.

This article traces that story — from a improbable underdog victory in the league's very first season, through the controversies and pandemic-era disruptions that tested it, to the billion-dollar broadcast deals and back-to-back champions of its most recent seasons.

1. Born From a Rival's Ashes

To understand why the IPL exists, you have to understand what it was built to kill. In 2007, a group of Indian businessmen and former cricketers, frustrated by the BCCI's refusal to organise a domestic T20 league of its own, launched the Indian Cricket League (ICL) — an unauthorised, privately funded T20 competition. The BCCI's response was swift and characteristically forceful: it banned any player who joined the ICL from BCCI-sanctioned cricket for life, and within months moved to launch its own, sanctioned alternative.

That alternative was the IPL, spearheaded by BCCI vice-president Lalit Modi, who is widely credited as the league's founding architect. Modi's pitch was audacious: instead of a national team playing a handful of exhibition matches, India would get city-based franchises, an English Premier League-style structure, a player auction to stock each squad, and international stars playing alongside India's best domestic talent — all broadcast in prime time with the production values of a Bollywood awards show.

The Timing Was Perfect

The league's launch could not have been better timed. Just months earlier, in September 2007, a young and largely inexperienced Indian team led by MS Dhoni had stunned the cricket world by winning the inaugural ICC World T20 in South Africa, beating Pakistan in a nail-biting final. Overnight, T20 cricket went from a format Indian fans barely tolerated to one the entire country was suddenly obsessed with. The IPL rode that wave from its very first ball.

Eight Cities, Eight Franchises

The league launched in 2008 with eight franchises, each representing a major Indian city: Chennai Super Kings, Delhi Daredevils, Kings XI Punjab, Kolkata Knight Riders, Mumbai Indians, Rajasthan Royals, Royal Challengers Bangalore, and Deccan Chargers. Franchise owners paid enormous sums for the rights — Mukesh Ambani's Reliance Group paid over 111 million dollars for the Mumbai franchise alone — a sign of just how seriously Indian big business took the opportunity, even before a single ball had been bowled.

2. The Underdog Who Started It All

If the IPL needed a founding myth, it got one in its very first season. Rajasthan Royals, assembled on the tournament's smallest budget and built around a squad of uncapped Indian domestic players stitched together by a 38-year-old Shane Warne, were widely expected to finish last. Bookmakers barely priced them into title contention.

Instead, Warne turned out to be exactly the kind of captain a young T20 team needed — part tactician, part psychologist, willing to trust unknown 19- and 20-year-olds with the ball in the final over of a tight game. Rajasthan won match after match they weren't supposed to win, and arrived at the final against a star-studded Chennai Super Kings side as unlikely champions-in-waiting. They won it in the most fitting way possible: a last-ball, three-wicket thriller that felt, in retrospect, like the exact story the fledgling league needed to prove that money and star power alone wouldn't decide who won.

A Template for Two Decades

That first season set a pattern the IPL would repeat again and again over the next eighteen years: relatively unheralded players becoming household names within weeks, franchises with modest reputations upsetting the tournament's giants, and finals decided by a handful of runs or a single dropped catch. It is this unpredictability, as much as the star power, that has kept audiences hooked season after season.

A Season Uprooted

The following year, in 2009, the league faced its first serious logistical crisis. With India's general elections scheduled for April and May, security resources that would normally protect IPL stadiums and travelling teams were unavailable. Rather than delay the tournament, the BCCI relocated the entire season to South Africa on short notice — a remarkable operational feat that also demonstrated the league's growing institutional confidence. Deccan Chargers, who had finished last in the inaugural season, won the trophy that year in Johannesburg, becoming the first team in IPL history to go from worst to first.

3. The Rise of the Dynasties: MI and CSK

If the early seasons were about proving the format could work, the years that followed were about two franchises turning consistency into dynasty. Mumbai Indians and Chennai Super Kings would go on to become the league's two most successful teams, each lifting the trophy five times — a level of sustained dominance that no other franchise has come close to matching.

Chennai's Culture of Calm

Chennai Super Kings, led from the franchise's very first match by MS Dhoni, built their success on something almost countercultural in a league built around glamour and turnover: stability. CSK retained core players season after season rather than chasing the biggest auction names, built a settled dressing room, and leaned on Dhoni's famously unflappable captaincy in pressure situations. The formula won them titles in 2010, 2011, 2018, 2021, and 2023 — the 2018 title arriving in particularly emotional circumstances, as the team returned from a two-year suspension over a betting scandal to win the trophy in their very first season back.

Mumbai's Machine

Mumbai Indians, under the captaincy of Rohit Sharma from 2013 onward, built a different kind of dynasty — one powered by deep pockets, shrewd scouting, and a knack for producing champion moments under extreme pressure. Two of their five titles, in 2017 and 2019, were won by a single run — still the two closest finals margins in IPL history. Their 2020 title, won entirely inside a bio-secure bubble in the UAE during the COVID-19 pandemic, capped off a stretch that made them the most feared team in the competition for the better part of a decade.

A Changing Guard

Kolkata Knight Riders, initially co-owned by Bollywood superstar Shah Rukh Khan, became the league's third-most successful franchise, winning titles in 2012, 2014, and most recently in 2024. Meanwhile Royal Challengers Bengaluru — for years the league's most star-studded team on paper, built around Virat Kohli, and for years its most heartbreaking to support — finally ended a seventeen-season wait for a maiden title in 2025, then defended it in 2026, joining Mumbai and Chennai as the only franchises to win the title in back-to-back years.

4. How the Format Evolved

The basic skeleton of an IPL season has stayed remarkably consistent since 2008: a round-robin league phase in which every team plays every other team, followed by a compressed playoff stage — Qualifier 1, an Eliminator, and Qualifier 2 — that ultimately produces two finalists. What has changed dramatically is everything around that skeleton.

From Eight Teams to Ten

The league's franchise map has shifted more than fans sometimes remember. Early expansion attempts brought in Pune Warriors India and Kochi Tuskers Kerala in 2011, both of which folded within a few seasons amid financial disputes with the BCCI. Deccan Chargers, champions in 2009, were terminated as a franchise in 2012 over payment defaults and replaced by a new franchise, Sunrisers Hyderabad, based in the same city. A two-year suspension of Chennai Super Kings and Rajasthan Royals following a 2013 spot-fixing scandal led to two temporary replacement franchises, Rising Pune Supergiant and Gujarat Lions, filling the gap for the 2016 and 2017 seasons. It was only in 2022 that the league settled into its current ten-team structure, adding Gujarat Titans and Lucknow Super Giants as permanent new franchises — with Gujarat Titans immediately announcing their arrival by winning the title in their debut season.

Rule Changes That Reshaped the Game

On the field, the IPL has repeatedly used its scale to trial rule changes that later influenced cricket globally. The Decision Review System, the Impact Player substitution rule, and various tweaks to powerplay regulations have all been tested or popularised through the IPL before spreading to other formats. The Impact Player rule in particular, introduced in 2023, allowed teams to make a like-for-like tactical substitution mid-match, fundamentally changing team-selection strategy and giving all-rounders and specialist bowlers a new lease of relevance.

The Auction as Theatre

Perhaps no single event captures the IPL's business model better than its player auction, held ahead of most seasons and broadcast as a standalone television event in its own right. Franchises bid, sometimes into the millions of dollars, for players in real time, turning a roster-building exercise into appointment viewing and a reliable source of headlines months before a ball is bowled.

5. Records, Rivalries, and Unforgettable Moments

Across nineteen seasons, a handful of individual performances and rivalries have come to define the league's identity in the public imagination.

Kohli's Season for the Ages

No individual batting season looms larger than Virat Kohli's 2016 campaign for Royal Challengers Bangalore, in which he scored 973 runs at an average above 80, including four centuries — a single-season run tally that remains unmatched more than a decade later. Kohli would go on to claim the Orange Cap again in 2024, underlining a level of consistency across a fifteen-year IPL career that few batters in the format's history can match.

The Bowlers Who Defied T20's Bias Toward Bat

On a tournament that has often been described as a batter's paradise, certain bowlers built reputations precisely by mastering its most dangerous phases. Dwayne Bravo's death-bowling craft for Chennai Super Kings and Bhuvneshwar Kumar's new-ball control for Sunrisers Hyderabad each produced multiple Purple Cap-winning seasons. Bravo's 32 wickets in 2013, later equalled by Harshal Patel in 2021, remains the record for most wickets taken in a single IPL season.

CSK vs MI: The League's Defining Rivalry

No fixture carries the weight of Chennai Super Kings against Mumbai Indians. The two most successful franchises in the league's history have met in the final on multiple occasions, and their regular-season meetings routinely draw the tournament's highest television ratings. The rivalry has been sharpened further by the personal duel between Dhoni and Rohit Sharma — two captains who between them have lifted the trophy ten times.

Debut-Season Champions

Only two franchises have ever won the title in their very first season in the competition: Rajasthan Royals in 2008 and Gujarat Titans in 2022, fourteen years apart. Both wins are held up as evidence that the IPL's auction system, for all its imperfections, genuinely does allow a well-assembled new roster to compete immediately against franchises with far longer histories.

6. The Business Behind the Boundaries

It is impossible to tell the IPL's story without talking about money, because money is, in many ways, the story. Brand consultancy valuations have placed the league's overall brand value in the multiple billions of dollars, and its media rights have become some of the most fiercely contested broadcast assets in global sport.

A Broadcast Deal That Stunned the Industry

In 2022, the BCCI sold the IPL's media rights for the 2023-2027 cycle in a package that split television and digital streaming rights between Disney Star and Reliance-owned Viacom18. The combined value of that deal placed the IPL, on a per-match basis, among the most valuable sports properties anywhere in the world — comparable to, and by some per-match calculations exceeding, leagues like the NFL and English Premier League. That single auction underlined how completely the league had transformed from a cricket board's side project into one of the most lucrative media properties on the planet.

Franchise Valuations

The franchises themselves have appreciated dramatically. Teams bought for tens of millions of dollars in the league's earliest ownership rounds are now valued, by various sports business trackers, in the hundreds of millions to over a billion dollars each. Mumbai Indians and Chennai Super Kings, the league's most successful teams on the field, are consistently ranked among its most valuable off it as well — a rare case in sport where sporting success and commercial success have moved almost perfectly in tandem.

A Talent Pipeline for World Cricket

Beyond broadcast revenue and franchise valuations, the IPL's most enduring economic contribution may be the talent pipeline it has built. The auction system exposes uncapped domestic Indian players to international-standard coaching, foreign teammates, and high-pressure finals cricket years before they might otherwise get that exposure through the national team. A striking number of India's next generation of international cricketers — batters and bowlers alike — have credited an early IPL contract as the turning point in their careers, long before they ever wore the national jersey.

7. Controversy, Crisis, and Resilience

No institution this large, this fast-growing, and this financially significant escapes controversy, and the IPL has weathered several genuine crises over its history — each of which, in its own way, tested whether the league's foundations were as solid as its balance sheets suggested.

The Spot-Fixing Scandal

The most serious crisis in the league's history came in 2013, when a spot-fixing scandal implicated players and, more damagingly, franchise owners connected to Chennai Super Kings and Rajasthan Royals. The fallout led to a two-year suspension for both franchises from IPL competition, a Supreme Court-mandated independent probe into BCCI governance, and lasting reputational damage that took years for both teams to fully recover from. Chennai's emotional 2018 title win, in their first season back after the ban, is widely read by fans as the franchise's true redemption arc.

A Pandemic Season Unlike Any Other

In 2020, as COVID-19 spread globally, the IPL made the unprecedented decision to relocate its entire season to the United Arab Emirates and play the tournament inside a strict bio-secure bubble, with no crowds in the stands. The following year's season was suspended mid-tournament after positive cases emerged inside team bubbles in India, before eventually being completed in the UAE later in the year. That the league managed to stage two full, competitively legitimate seasons under those conditions is often cited within Indian sport as a case study in operational resilience.

Questions the League Still Faces

The IPL's success has not silenced its critics. Concerns persist about an increasingly congested global cricket calendar squeezing out bilateral international cricket and domestic first-class competitions; about the toll a season of near-daily high-intensity T20 cricket takes on fast bowlers' bodies; and about smaller cricket boards worldwide struggling to retain their best players against IPL contracts that can dwarf what a national board is able to offer. These are not questions the league has fully answered — but they are, in a sense, the price of having become indispensable to the sport's economics.

8. A Legacy Still Being Written

Nineteen seasons in, it is worth stepping back to appreciate just how thoroughly the Indian Premier League has reshaped the sport it was once accused of cheapening. It has produced eight different champion franchises, turned uncapped domestic cricketers into millionaires and national heroes within a single season, and built two genuine sporting dynasties in Mumbai Indians and Chennai Super Kings whose rivalry now anchors the league's calendar every year.

It has also exported its model around the cricketing world. The Pakistan Super League, Big Bash League, Caribbean Premier League, and the newer Major League Cricket in the United States all borrow directly from the blueprint Lalit Modi and the BCCI built in 2007 — city-based franchises, marquee auctions, and prime-time production values. Whatever else can be said about the IPL, it did not just create a successful tournament. It created the template that an entire generation of T20 cricket leagues has since followed.

What Comes Next

Royal Challengers Bengaluru's back-to-back titles in 2025 and 2026 have added a new chapter to a rivalry table that once looked permanently owned by Mumbai and Chennai, suggesting the league's competitive balance is, if anything, widening rather than narrowing after nearly two decades. With media rights locked in through 2027, a settled ten-team structure, and a pipeline of young Indian talent — symbolised by teenage stars like Vaibhav Sooryavanshi claiming an Orange Cap once dominated by seasoned internationals — the IPL heads into its third decade with its commercial and competitive foundations arguably stronger than at any point in its history.

What began in 2008 as a gamble on whether Indian cricket fans would embrace a shortened, franchise-based, entertainment-first version of their sport has become something far larger: the financial and cultural centre of gravity for cricket worldwide. Whatever comes next for the game, it is very likely to arrive first in the IPL.